During the period 1500–1775, the nature of warfare in Europe changed radically with the development of gunpowder weapons. Firearms evolved from the slow and unreliable arquebus and the equally unwieldy matchlock musket to the far superior flintlock. Artillery improved in its variety, mobility, and rate of fire. The pike was eventually to be supplanted by the bayonet. Even more significant than these technological developments, however, were the fundamental changes in the methods with which European armies were recruited and organized, and in their battlefield tactics.

MERCENARIES TO REGULARS

In the 16th century, standing armies were only a small part of European forces. The most typical fighting man was the mercenary, part of a company that sold its services to a monarch preparing for war. Mercenary bands of Swiss pikemen and German Landsknechts fought on the same battlefields, and broadly with the same tactics, as Spanish *tercios*, which were formations of regular soldiers, containing both pikemen and musketeers, in the permanent employ of the king of Spain. It was often impossible to tell the difference between mercenaries and regulars whether on or off the battlefield. Both were liable to mutiny when their payment failed – as it frequently did – and turn to the plunder and massacre of civilians.

Pikemen on the defensive
English Civil War soldiers form a lethal hedge of pikes. One of the duties of the pikemen, who wore breastplates and helmets, was to defend the unarmoured musketeers from attack.







